

Advanced Modal Verb Chart

1. Expressing Degrees of Certainty/Probability

Function	Present/Future	Past (Modal Perfect)	Example Sentences
Strong certainty (positive)	must	must have + past participle	• She must be the director of the company. • He must have been informed about the changes.
Strong certainty (negative)	can't/cannot	can't/cannot have + past participle	• They can't be serious about the proposal. • The team can't have completed the project so quickly.
Strong probability	will	will have + past participle	• They will arrive by 5 pm. • They will have reached a decision by now.
Medium probability	should ought to	should have + past participle ought to have + past participle	• The package should arrive tomorrow. • The package should have arrived yesterday. • The documents ought to have been signed last week.
Medium possibility	may could	may have + past participle could have + past participle	• The CEO may approve the budget. • The board may have discussed this already. • This solution could work. • They could have won with better preparation.
Slight possibility	might	might have + past participle	• She might join us later. • They might have overlooked this detail.

2. Expressing Obligation, Necessity, and Prohibition

Function	Present/Future	Past (Modal Perfect)	Example Sentences
Strong obligation	must have to need to	had to have + past participle needed to have + past participle	• You must submit the report by Friday. • The contract had to have been finalized before the merger. • We needed to have secured those permits earlier.
Medium obligation	should ought to	should have + past participle ought to have + past participle	• You should attend the conference. • You should have informed me earlier. • Companies ought to have invested in cybersecurity.
Absence of obligation	don't have to don't need to needn't	didn't have to + infinitive didn't need to + infinitive needn't have + past participle	• You don't have to finish this today. • You didn't have to work overtime. • You needn't have spent so much money.
Prohibition	must not cannot	must not have + past participle cannot have + past participle	• Employees must not share confidential information. • They must not have followed protocol. • Visitors cannot enter this area. • They cannot have authorized this expenditure.

3. Expressing Ability and Permission

Function	Present/Future	Past (Modal Perfect)	Example Sentences
Ability	can be able to	could was/were able to could have + past participle	• She can speak five languages. • He could swim by age four. • They were able to solve the problem. • We could have implemented a better solution.
Permission	can may could might	could have + past participle might have + past participle	• You can use my office while I'm away. • May I ask a question? • Could I see the report? • You could have borrowed my laptop. • They might have allowed it under different circumstances.
Request	can could would will	could have + past participle would have + past participle	• Can you help me with this? • Could you send the documents? • Would you mind reviewing this? • Could you have notified us sooner? • Would you have preferred a different approach?

4. Expressing Advice, Criticism, and Regret

Function	Present/Future	Past (Modal Perfect)	Example Sentences
Advice	should ought to had better	should have + past participle ought to have + past participle	• You should review the contract carefully. • We ought to consider all options. • You'd better leave now. • The team should have consulted experts. • They ought to have tested the system more thoroughly.
Criticism	should ought to	should have + past participle ought to have + past participle	• The management should address these concerns. • They should have anticipated these problems. • The company ought to have disclosed this information.
Regret	--	should have + past participle could have + past participle would have + past participle	• I should have studied harder. • We could have won the contract. • They would have attended if they had known.

5. Expressing Hypothetical Situations and Conditional Results

Function	Present/Future	Past (Modal Perfect)	Example Sentences
Hypothetical present	would could might	--	• This approach would solve our problems. • The investment could yield significant returns. • The technology might change the industry.
Hypothetical past	--	would have + past participle could have + past participle might have + past participle	• The project would have succeeded with better planning. • We could have avoided these issues. • Their strategy might have worked in a different market.
Unreal conditional	would could might	would have + past participle could have + past participle might have + past participle	• If prices fell, demand would increase. • If they had invested earlier, they would have made a profit. • If resources were available, we could complete this sooner. • If we had known, we could have prepared better.

6. Expressing Formal and Official Functions

Function	Present/Future	Past (Modal Perfect)	Example Sentences
Formal suggestion	shall	shall have + past participle	• Shall we proceed with the meeting? • The parties shall have concluded negotiations by the specified date.
Formal obligation	shall	shall have + past participle	• The applicant shall provide all required documentation. • The contractor shall have completed all work by June 30th.
Formal request/offer	would might	would have + past participle might have + past participle	• Would you be willing to reconsider? • Might I suggest an alternative? • Would you have preferred a different arrangement? • Might I have been misinformed about the situation?